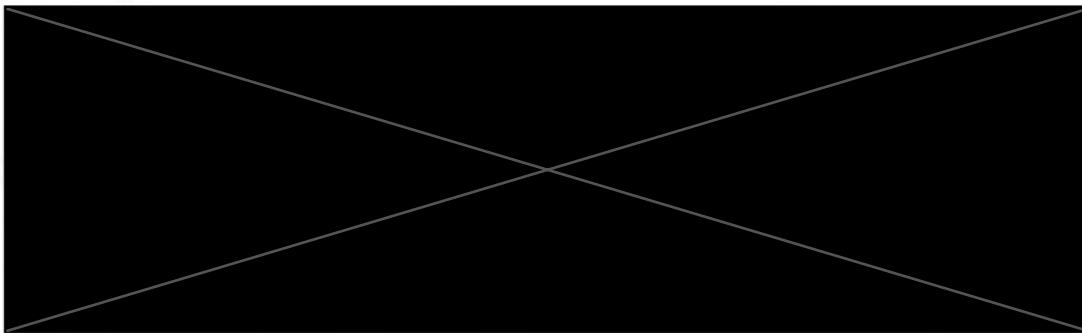




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10 January 1998

"MYSTERY FRAGMENTS FROM ALLEGED UFO"

(Universidade de Escola de Mato Grosso, Cuiabá, Brasil.) Dr. Octavio Porros, head of the earth sciences department and Milton Riás, professor of mineral chemistry at the University College of Mato Grosso, Cuiabá, announced the recovery of hundreds of mysterious fragments of an unknown material from an alleged UFO landing site in the Serra Do Tombador mountain range, approx. 350 kilometers south-west of the southern Brazilian city.

"We have no idea what these fragments are," said Professor Riás in a lengthy taped article recorded on February 3 of this year. "To say we are puzzled is an understatement. We are very excited. Whatever this substance is, it has several amazing properties which bear careful study."

The actual alleged 'UFO landing' occurred sometime late in October, 1997, and was witnessed by gold and silver miners at an isolated camp in the wooded hills of the Serra Do Tombador. The miners, who tend (Riás said) to be secretive about all their affairs, were the first to collect some of the fragments, but word of the landing and the existence of physical evidence only reached the outside world in late November or early December. Professor Riás, his brother Dante (a mining engineer), and a third man described as "a family friend", travelled to the mining camp between Christmas and New Years. "It was my brother who first heard the stories of the landing and the fragments," said Professor Riás. "He considered the source reliable enough to want to investigate for himself. He convinced me to come along."

Dante Riás' "reliable source", an as yet unidentified miner, led the trio of investigators up to a flat, barren pampas above the wooded ravine where the miners work the cliffs for gold. "The miners sometimes used the flat area above the camp as a soccer field," said Riás. "The elevation is about 3500 feet. It is very level high grassland. A local rancher grazes his herd on it for part of the year. A small plane could easily land there. Apparently it has not been uncommon to see lights in the sky over this area. They have been seen for many years."

Riás, who said he was expecting to find marks of a landing of some kind of craft, was disappointed. "I had visions of something like the crop circles I had seen pictures of," he said, laughing. "However there was nothing like that. Just grass." It was only after their guide led them to a specific area that the investigators began to notice the dark irregular fragments on the ground beneath their feet, some partially embedded in the soil among the grass clumps, and others which, according to Riás, looked as if they had just been dropped there moments before. "As nearly as we could determine," said Riás, "the fragments covered a roughly circular area, circumference of about 200 meters, with the greatest concentration in a definite ring 10 meters in from the outer-most edge of the circle. We had no difficulty seeing them. There were tens of thousands of small dark pieces on the ground around us. They were very evident once we knew what to look for. We collected samples from various places in the circle, took photographs and some preliminary measurements. My brother tested the site with his Geiger counter, and found only slightly higher than normal readings. Tests with a directional compass showed some magnetizing effect, but this was only slight and inconclusive. The site needs to be studied carefully with proper equipment sometime in the future."

Upon his return to Cuiabá, Riás began a series of physical tests to determine nature and composition of the fragments. "We brought home two hundred and sixty-two pieces," he said. "The smallest is about the size of a dried pea. The largest is an irregular, somewhat rod-like fragment measuring six cm by two cm by two cm. All the pieces are highly irregular in shape and have jagged edges, as if they have been broken up. That is why we started calling them fragments. They looked like shards of some broken thing, like a huge broken ceramic pot. It is impossible to tell whether these breaks are old or new. There is no apparent weathering on the edges of the fragments."

Riás described the substance of the fragments as appearing non-metallic, "and not like any stone I am familiar with." He said it looked to him like a manufactured substance -- like a ceramic or a plastic. "It is so difficult to describe," he said. "It is a very very hard material but it also has a vaguely rubber-like feel to its surface. The color is very dark grey, and not at all glossy, very dull." Riás went on to say the substance has a specific gravity of 2.72, "very similar to aluminum." It is a poor conductor of electricity. "We have not yet discovered its melting point. We have

subjected it to heat in excess of 2,500 C. It neither melted or burned. It is utterly resistant to corrosion from the usual acids."

When asked if the mystery substance was radioactive, Riás said: "At first the fragments registered as being slightly more radioactive than you would expect from any randomly selected stone, in other words, slightly above normal background radiation. But these levels have dropped to normal in all but one of the samples which actually seems to fluctuate in its readings from day to day, with high spikes of both alpha and beta emissions. We have however detected no gamma ray, indicating to us that the substance, whatever it is, is probably not a secondary product of nuclear fission, that is to say, it is not nuclear waste of any kind, as someone has suggested. Nevertheless, we are keeping that one fragment in special containment, just in case. We really do not know what we are dealing with. We have to be cautious."

The material proved to be so hard, it required the use of a hydraulic press to crush one small fragment into fine particles for some of Riás' tests. When asked about the results of tests to determine the composition of the fragments, he said: "The more tests we apply, the more baffled we are. The strangest result so far is from chromatic spectrography, which should have been able to pinpoint the material's constituents. However, the spectrograph reading cannot be correct. The machine tells us the fragments are made from a mixture of almost pure methane and ammonia, with trace amounts of carbon. This is clearly impossible. Methane and ammonia are gases. They only exist as solids when frozen at very low temperatures. These fragments are not frozen gas, at least not 'frozen' in any sense of the word I know. In fact, most people who have handled the fragments have noted they feel slightly warm to the touch." Riás went on to say that in spite of this feeling, thermometer reading showed no real variance between the temperature of the fragments and the ambient temperature. "They are not giving off heat," he said.

He was then asked by the interviewer about rumors that the fragments melted through ice cubes even at sub-zero temperatures. "That is not exactly true," explained Riás. "One of my students did a test, laying a fragment on an ice cube in the open lab. Within about a minute and a half the fragment had passed through the cube, leaving a hole in the ice. There was some melting of the cube, but I thought the melt water looked like the result of normal exposure to warm air. I then personally repeated the experiment in a sub-zero freezer. The fragment began to pass through the ice and as I watched, the hole behind the object filled in with recrystallized ice. After one minute and thirty-seven seconds the fragment had passed entirely through the four cm thick ice cube leaving only a white line of recrystallized ice to mark its passage. I believe the

fragment was not melting the ice, but rather pushing the compacted water crystals aside somehow. This is the single strangest property of the material. These ice experiments have been repeated hundreds of times now. The effect is always the same."

When asked where he thought the fragments had come from, Professor Riás said he did not know. "They correspond to nothing I have seen in over twenty years as a chemist. They seem to violate natural laws as we understand those laws. However, much more study is needed." When asked bluntly if the fragments were not of this earth or if he thought they came from a UFO, Riás said: "First you will have to tell me what a UFO is. I have never seen one. I do not know if these fragments came from somewhere other than this planet, and if they did, I do not know how they got here. None of the miners saw a craft, or at least none of them said they did. They saw lights in the sky. That could mean anything."

Asked if he would be giving out the exact location of the site in the Serra Do Tombador range, Riás said not until he could mount a proper expedition to the area again. "I have, however, already shared samples of our fragments with colleagues in France, Germany and Japan. They are in the process of repeating our experiments and confirming our readings. Frankly, they have better equipment than we have at our disposal here. They may find something we have missed."